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Research methodology



Phd



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FINANCIAL LITERACY ASSINGMENT – UAE CONTEXT

Scenario 1 and Scenario 2

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1 Scenario 1

Scenario Summary

Ahmed is a fresh graduate working in Dubai Media City. He has a monthly salary of AED 8,000. His salary is decent for a recent graduate, but a major portion of it is being spent on lifestyle-related expenses. These include dining out, entertainment, and subscriptions. Suddenly, he is faced with an unexpected car repair cost of AED 2,500. Since, his savings are very limited, this has created a financial pressure on him. The issues identified in this case are weak budgeting and insufficient emergency savings. Specially, when living in UAE's high-cost environment.

1.1 Monthly Surplus or Deficit

Monthly Income:

- Salary = AED 8,000

Monthly Expenses:

- Rent = AED 3,000
- Groceries = AED 800
- Utilities/Internet = AED 300
- Phone/Data = AED 400
- Transportation = AED 600
- Gym Membership = AED 500
- Dining Out/Delivery = AED 1,200
- Entertainment = AED 400
- Subscriptions = AED 300\

Total Expenses:

$$= 3,000 + 800 + 300 + 400 + 600 + 500 + 1,200 + 400 + 300$$

$$= AED 7,500$$

Monthly Surplus:

$$= 8,000 - 7,500$$

$$= AED 500$$

Ahmed's income is slightly higher than his expenses. Hence, we can say that he is living within his means currently. However, the monthly surplus is extremely small and hence it does not provide adequate financial security.

1.2 50/30/20 Rule Analysis

Needs:

- Rent = AED 3,000
- Groceries = AED 800
- Utilities = AED 300
- Phone = AED 400
- Transportation = AED 600

$$Total\ Needs = AED\ 5,100$$

Wants:

- Gym = AED 500
- Dining Out = AED 1,200
- Entertainment = AED 400
- Subscriptions = AED 300

$$Total\ Wants = AED\ 2,400$$

Savings:

- Remaining amount = AED 500

Percentages

$$Needs\ Percentage: (5100 \div 8000) \times 100 = 63.75\%$$

Wants Percentage: $(2400 \div 8000) \times 100 = 30\%$

Savings Percentage: $(500 \div 8000) \times 100 = 6.25\%$

Ahmed's monthly spendings does not follow the 50/30/20 budgeting rule at all. His savings are extremely low while his essential living expenses are very high.

1.3 Immediate Spending Cuts

To cover the AED 2,500 car repair, Ahmed should reduce unnecessary lifestyle expenses immediately.

Suggested reductions:

- Dining Out: reduce from AED 1,200 to AED 300
Savings = AED 900
- Entertainment: reduce from AED 400 to AED 100
Savings = AED 300
- Subscriptions: reduce from AED 300 to AED 100
Savings = AED 200
- Gym Membership: temporarily pause
Savings = AED 500
- Reduce taxi usage and rely more on metro
Savings = AED 200

Total Potential Savings:

$$900 + 300 + 200 + 500 + 200 = 2,100$$

Ahmed already has a monthly surplus of AED 500.

Total Available Amount:

$$2,100 + 500 = 2,600$$

This amount is enough to cover the AED 2,500 car repair without borrowing money or using credit cards.

1.4 Emergency Fund Requirement

Ahmed should maintain an emergency fund equal to at least 3–6 months of living expenses.

3-month emergency fund:

$$7500 \times 3 = 22,500$$

6-month emergency fund:

$$7500 \times 6 = 45,000$$

This is particularly important in the UAE because employment visas are linked to jobs, and there are limited unemployment benefits available. A fund is needed to cover rent and living costs during this high-stress transition.

1.5 Revised Budget Including AED 1,000 Savings

Revised Budget:

- Rent = 3,000
- Groceries = 800
- Utilities = 300
- Phone = 300
- Transportation = 500
- Gym = 200
- Dining Out = 500
- Entertainment = 150
- Subscriptions = 100

New Total Expenses:

$$3000 + 800 + 300 + 300 + 500 + 200 + 500 + 150 + 100 = 5,850$$

New Savings:

$$8000 - 5850 = 2,150$$

Under this revised budget, Ahmed can comfortably save more than AED 1,000 each month toward an emergency fund.

2 Scenario 2

Scenario Summary

Sara works in Abu Dhabi and earns AED 15,000 a month. Yet she has built up multiple credit card debts which charge her excessively high monthly interest rates. Her financial status is impacted by the combination of her excessive credit card usage and her debt interest rates, as she is only able to make monthly payments of AED 4,000. The process of debt management needs to be executed in an effective way because it will help reduce her interest costs and improve her AECB credit rating.

2.1 Credit Utilisation Rate and Effect on AECB Score

Outstanding Balances

- ADCB Card = AED 12,000
- Emirates NBD Card = AED 6,000
- FAB Card = AED 0

Total Debt

$$12,000 + 6,000 = 18,000$$

Total Credit Limit

$$15,000 + 8,000 + 20,000 = 43,000$$

Credit Utilisation Rate

$$(18,000 \div 43,000) \times 100 = 41.86\%$$

Sara's utilisation rate is 41.86%, which is above the recommended 30% level. High utilisation may negatively affect her AECB credit score.

2.2 Monthly Interest Charges

$$\text{ADCB Card: } 12,000 \times 2.5\% = 300$$

$$\text{Monthly interest} = \text{AED } 300$$

Emirates NBD Card: $6,000 \times 2.8\% = 168$

Monthly interest = AED 168

Total Monthly Interest: $300 + 168 = 468$

Total monthly interest = AED 468

2.3 Avalanche Method Repayment Strategy

According to the Avalanche method, it is best to pay the debt which has the highest interest rate first. Since, more the interest rate, more amount will be charged as interest from the customer.

Interest Rate Comparison

- Emirates NBD = 2.8%
- ADCB = 2.5%

Hence, Sara must pay off the Emirates NBD card loan first. This is because it carries the higher interest rate among the two. This strategy minimizes total interest costs.

2.4 Balance Transfer Evaluation

FAB offers a 0% balance transfer for 12 months with a 3% transfer fee.

Transfer Fee

$$18,000 \times 3\% = 540$$

Transfer fee = AED 540

Estimated Interest Without Transfer

Current Monthly Interest Charges

ADCB Card

Monthly Interest = Principal $\times$ Interest Rate

$$= 12,000 \times 2.5\%$$

$$= 300$$

Emirates NBD Card

Monthly Interest = Principal $\times$ Interest Rate

$$= 6,000 \times 2.8\%$$

$$= 168$$

Total Monthly Interest

$$300 + 168 = 468$$

Total monthly interest = AED 468

Sara plans to repay an amount of AED 4,000 monthly. Her outstanding balance will keep on reducing each month. Due to this, the interest charges will also decrease with time gradually. Hence the interest charges will not be fixed at AED 468 monthly.

Based on the repayment schedule, the estimated total interest cost without using the balance transfer is approximately AED 1,392.

Potential Savings

$$1,392 - 540 = 852$$

Potential savings = **AED 852**

Therefore, Sara should use the balance transfer offer because the transfer fee is lower than the total interest that she would otherwise pay.

2.5 Time Required to Repay Debt

Total Debt = AED 18,000

Monthly Repayment = AED 4,000

Since interest is charged on the remaining balance each month, the balance decreases gradually over time.

Approximate Repayment Schedule

Month	Estimated Ending Balance (AED)
1	14,468
2	10,843
3	7,123

Month	Estimated Ending Balance (AED)
4	3,307
5	0

Based on this repayment pattern, Sara would take approximately **5 months** to fully repay the debt.

Her final payment in the fifth month would be lower than AED 4,000 because the remaining balance would already be small.

2.6 Future Impact on AECB Score

As Sara continues paying down her credit card debt, her AECB score is likely to improve gradually.

The main reasons are:

- Her credit utilisation ratio is bound to decrease. This is because the outstanding balances become lower.
- Her payment history can be improved by regular and timely monthly repayments.
- From the lender's perspective, a lower dependence on credit cards reduces the financial risk.

Sara's credit score suffers because her credit utilisation exceeds the 30% limit which experts recommend. Her AECB score will increase to above 700 when she decreases her credit card balances and keeps making payments on schedule.

A stronger AECB score would improve her chances of receiving loans, credit cards, or better interest rates in the future.

3 Personalized Learning Reflection – Future Financial Goal

The financial scenarios I studied showed me that emergency funds and operational debt control help create financial security. The United Arab Emirates requires residents to maintain financial stability because their job and residency visas depend on their active employment status and they have limited access to unemployment benefits. People need to establish their financial stability because they must prepare for unexpected events that include job loss and emergency expenses.

My financial objective is to accumulate a three-month emergency fund within the next year, based on what I've learnt. Financial security during uncertain times brings people peace of mind, which makes this goal essential to achieve.

To achieve my goal, I plan to monitor my monthly spending while reducing all unnecessary expenditures for entertainment and dining out. I will establish a monthly salary percentage which I will save before I spend money on non-essential items. I will avoid unnecessary credit card debt while making all required payments to maintain my financial health. My financial discipline and long-term financial health will improve through these measures.

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